

« IT IS LIKE RAISING CHILDREN »»

Rahul Dravid reflects on coaching, continuity and cricket's changing landscape

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From traditional red-ball cricket to the immense popularity of T20s, Rahul Dravid has witnessed the evolution of the game from close quarters. The former India captain and erstwhile national team coach is now back with Rajasthan Royals as its head coach in the Indian Premier League after a decade.

He believes that, going forward, it is important to ensure that league cricket 'coexists' with international cricket.

In an exclusive interview with *Sportstar*, Dravid spoke about his return to the Royals as head coach, the rise of young cricketers, and why he was not particularly in favour of the Impact Player rule during his stint with the Indian team.

You returned to the IPL as a coach after a decade. How has the experience been? What are the changes that you see?

Yeah, it's good to be back at RR after so many years. When you look at the league over the last decade, you can see how much it has grown. It was always a big event, but its popularity has soared even further. When you travel to different cities, the scale and impact of the league are even more evident.

The IPL has become significantly bigger and, in many ways, more professional. The level of preparation and planning has increased considerably compared to earlier

years.

Teams are now investing heavily in extended support staff and working with players not just during the IPL but throughout the year. There's a continuous engagement with players, which wasn't as common in the past.

The overall standard of the league keeps improving. The growth of Indian talent over the last decade has played a major role in this. You can see its impact in our white-ball performances at the international level. Since the strength of the IPL is largely driven by local players, their improvement has directly contributed to raising the league's quality.

This year's auction saw the Royals part ways with some notable players and focus on acquiring young Indian players. What was the idea behind it?

Over the last three years, RR built a really strong team and enjoyed a successful period. Letting go of some key players was tough, but that's the nature of the league.

The rules allow teams to retain only six players, which naturally leads to difficult decisions. In an ideal